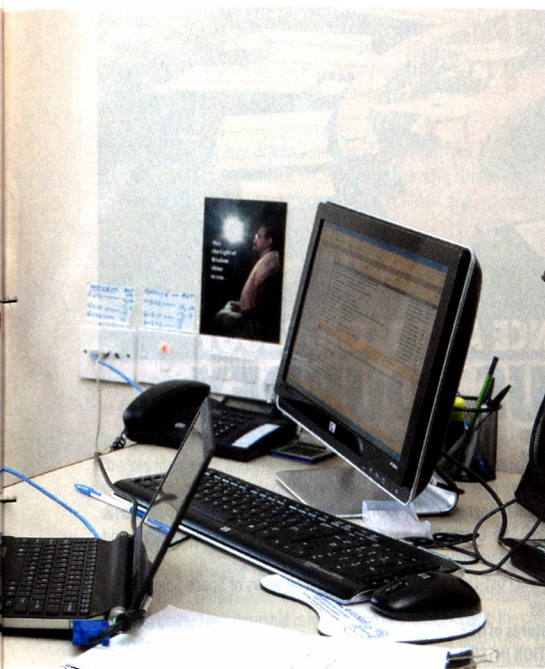




“I wanted to do something of my own. Now I set the agenda and lay down the terms of engagement.”

RENUKA RAMNATH, 48
TRANSITION: From managing director of ICICI Ventures to founder of Multiple Alternate Asset Managers

BIG IDEA: Channelising money from long-term capital providers to deserving entrepreneurs.

CHALLENGE: Raising capital and getting a good team in place as it is a new fund.

Khattar managed to snag Rs 108 crore in Series-A funding from ICICI Venture Capital and PremjiInvest, even though he had a bit of “chasing to do”. Likewise, Ramnath’s first office in Mumbai’s Worli was offered by a friend. “Ninety-nine out of 100 people who helped me out approached me,” she says. A study by UK-based NatWest Bank showed that silver entrepreneurs were twice as likely to survive the first three years, which would make them attractive to investors. That could apply here too.

In April 2009, as the recession was beginning to rear its head, Ramnath stepped down as the head of ICICI Ventures to found Multiple Alternate Asset Managers, a private asset management firm. The 48-year-old, who had been an executive for over 20 years, couldn’t resist the idea of creating something new of her own, whatever the economic headwinds.

However, even though most entrepreneurs are in an industry familiar to them, being the new kid on the block isn’t easy. As a start-up, you have to think and behave like one, and keep your ear to the ground. For one, cost is important. So, if Khattar is a stickler for turning off lights, Ramnath has started using non-refundable, cheap air tickets, “and no business class till I earn it”. But more importantly, she says, one has to “move on from the past and recalibrate”.

Setting a culture for the company is as important, says Srivastava. “Actions speak volumes about a company’s values, so spend a lot of time thinking about your company DNA and set precedents.” Brar will agree. Reddy and he have, for example, fixed a per day travel allowance for the company’s staff, including the chairman himself. Brar gets \$175-\$200, which includes travel, transport and stay per day when he is abroad. “It’s a discipline where cost management is practised at all levels,” he says.

Karwal says that entrepreneurs often fail due to lack of good people. “Be it building a team, aligning it to a common purpose and retaining it, choosing the right people is the biggest challenge. Everything else follows.”

Entrepreneurship is about urge, not age, and these pioneers prove it. ■

“I had already missed the bus in IT, but that opportunity was yet to come in R&D services in life sciences.”

D.S. BRAR, 56
TRANSITION: From CEO and managing director of Ranbaxy to Chairman of GVK Biosciences

BIG IDEA: Drug discovery and contract research for pharma companies. The global outsourcing market is worth \$60 bn of which drug discovery is \$8 bn.

CHALLENGE: Increasing the pool of innovative products while reducing R&D spends.



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